Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

March 30, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S14 -- 1997-2001 Model Year Ford Econoline E-150 and E-350 Wagons, and Certain E-350 Vans With Ambulance Prep Package -- Mid-Ship Fuel Tank Cracks

Summary

- Ford Action -- Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving the fuel tank on certain 1997 through 2001 Model Year Ford Econoline E-150 and E-350 Wagons, and certain E-350 Vans with ambulance prep package. These vehicles were built from April 9, 1996 through November 14, 2000.

- Number of Vehicles Involved -- Approximately 167,000 vehicles (151,000 in the United States, 7,600 in Canada, 6,200 in Mexico, and the remainder in export markets).

- Affect on Vehicle Operation -- In certain severe-duty applications involving operation at or near Gross Vehicle Weight with frequent twisting of the vehicle body, such as off road, rough road or speed bump events, the 35 gallon mid-ship fuel tank may develop a crack where it contacts the frame cross member. A cracked fuel tank could leak fuel and, in sufficient quantity and in the presence of an ignition source, could potentially result in a fire.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will inspect the affected area of the fuel tank and, if cracked, replace it. Insulator pads will be installed on all vehicles to reduce the stress levels in the fuel tank.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S14 5d/rjw/ae

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S14 -- 1997-2001 MODEL YEAR FORD ECONOLINE E-150 AND E-350 WAGONS, AND CERTAIN E-350 VANS WITH AMBULANCE PREP PACKAGE -- MID-SHIP FUELTANK CRACKS

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

Certain 1997-2001 Model Year Ford Econoline E-150 and E-350 Wagons, and E-350 Vans with ambulance prep package equipped with the 35 gallon mid-ship fuel tank, and built at the Lorain Assembly Plant from April 9, 1996 through November 14, 2000 are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 151,000 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Unknown, but believed to be less than one percent.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

When operated in severe-service applications (at or near Gross Vehicle Weight Rating with frequent body twist events that may occur during off road, rough road or speed bump events), the mid-ship fuel tank may develop an approximately one inch long crack where it contacts the frame cross member. If the fuel tank cracks, it may leak fuel. Fuel leakage in sufficient quantities and in the presence of an ignition source could potentially result in a fire.

As of March 21, 2001, Ford is aware of 44 reports of cracked fuel tanks on the subject vehicles. None of the reports allege that a fire, accident, injury, or fatality occurred.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

Ford first became aware of reports of this condition during 1998 when a few logging fleets in Canada began reporting it. Initial analysis revealed that the fleets were overloading the vehicles and operating them in extremely severe off road conditions. A review of reports located 22 occurrences of the condition, all on the logging fleet vehicles in Canada and Ford concluded that no further action was warranted due to the absence of any defect trend. During mid-2000, a similar crack occurred on a durability vehicle at Ford's Arizona Proving Grounds. Further analysis revealed that fit of the fuel tank to the cross member on the frame was a point contact rather than the intended large area of contact. A review of reports identified primarily logging and mining fleets with severe off-road duty cycles reporting the condition. On November 14, 2000 the top of the fuel tank was revised to restore the intended fit to the cross member and two insulators were added between the fuel tank and frame on vehicles in production. During early 2001, a shuttle fleet reported the condition and Ford's analysis determined that speed bumps could also contribute to the condition. Recent vehicle testing has also confirmed that installation of the insulator on uncracked fuel tanks will significantly reduce stress levels in the fuel tank.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford will notify owners of record of affected vehicles to return vehicles to dealers for inspection of the fuel tank and, if cracked, replacement of the tank. In addition, all vehicles will have insulators installed to reduce stress levels in the fuel tank and reduce the likelihood of future cracks. This service will be performed at no charge to owners. Ford currently anticipates that owner notification will occur on or before the week of April 23, 2001.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press Statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. Notices to dealers and owners from Ford Customer Service Division will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S14 to this action.